

Global & Regional Traditions

Gaye holud, pasupu, vatna, the perfumers of Grasse, and the oud tradition, taught by name

Learning Objectives

- Name and describe five regional and global scent-and-adornment traditions by name and history
- Distinguish the ingredient and technique differences between each tradition
- Apply at least one tradition's technique on a practice model
- Explain why "turmeric ceremony" is not one single, undifferentiated tradition across India

One ingredient, many ceremonies

Turmeric-based pre-wedding rituals appear across India under different names, different accompanying rites, and genuinely different regional character — treating them as one interchangeable "turmeric ceremony" erases exactly the kind of regional distinction Course VI's Module Twelve already taught you to name precisely.

Bengali gaye holud

Gaye holud — literally "turmeric on the body" — is the Bengali pre-wedding ceremony in which turmeric paste is applied by family members, traditionally believed to brighten the skin before the wedding, often performed for the bride and groom on the same or adjoining days at each of their respective family homes.

South Indian pasupu-kunkuma

In Tamil and broader South Indian tradition, pasupu (turmeric) is applied alongside kunkuma (vermilion powder) in a ritual carrying both beautification and auspicious significance, frequently as part of a broader women's gathering ceremony.

Punjabi vatna

Vatna is the Punjabi pre-wedding paste ceremony, made from turmeric, sandalwood, and mustard oil, applied by family members amid singing and celebration, sharing the same underlying beautification purpose as gaye holud and pasupu-kunkuma while remaining its own distinct regional tradition.

A global tradition: the perfumers of Grasse

The town of Grasse in southern France has been recognised as the historic centre of Western perfumery since the sixteenth century, its flower fields and centuries of accumulated craft earning it UNESCO-recognised cultural heritage status for perfume-making — a Western parallel worth knowing by name alongside Kannauj's own centuries-old tradition.

A second global tradition: oud

Oud — the deeply prized, resinous wood formed when Aquilaria trees become infected with a specific mould — is central to Middle Eastern perfumery tradition, valued for millennia and, gram for gram, among the most expensive natural raw materials in perfumery, worth introducing to any client drawn to deep, woody, oriental-family fragrance.

Key Terms

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Practical Activity · Recreate a Tradition

Choose one named turmeric-ceremony tradition from this module and prepare its specific paste formulation, noting how its ingredients or method differ from the other two. **Photograph the result for your capstone portfolio.**